

Day 36 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: Spirit of Federalism: Centre-State Relationships

READING MATERIAL

Covers how scholars have characterised India's federal-unitary blend, the constitutional bodies that manage Centre-State relations, and the Sarkaria Commission's landmark review. Real exam evidence favours precise theorist-to-term and Article-to-body matching over general description.

Q: Real exam: Which scholars are correctly matched to which description of Indian federalism — Quasi-Federal, Co-operative Federalism, Bargaining Federalism, and Federation with a Centralising Tendency?

A: K.C. Wheare → 'Quasi-Federal' (federal in form, unitary in spirit). Granville Austin → 'Co-operative Federalism' (Centre and States as cooperative partners, not rivals). BOTH confirmed correct by a real exam question, which also confirmed 'Bargaining Federalism' is NOT C.R. Dass's term and 'Federation with a Centralising Tendency' is NOT Jawaharlal Nehru's — the latter description is actually most associated with the British constitutional scholar Sir Ivor Jennings.

Q: Real exam: Match Articles 280, 263, 262, and 279A to the bodies/mechanisms they establish.

A: Article 280: Finance Commission (recommends Centre-State revenue distribution). Article 263: Inter-State Council (resolves Centre-State and inter-State coordination issues). Article 262: Inter-State (river) Water Dispute adjudication — Parliament can bar the Supreme Court's jurisdiction over such disputes by law. Article 279A: Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council (added by the 101st Amendment, 2016) — all four confirmed via a real exam's match-the-following question.

Q: Real exam: What did the Sarkaria Commission (1983) actually recommend regarding Article 356, and what's the common misconception?

A: The Sarkaria Commission did NOT recommend scrapping Article 356 — a real exam confirmed this claim as INCORRECT. Its actual recommendation was that Article 356 (President's Rule) should be used sparingly, only as a last resort, with adequate safeguards against misuse — a more moderate reform than outright abolition.

Q: Real exam: What did the Sarkaria Commission recommend about residuary powers of taxation, and what's the common misconception?

A: The Commission did NOT recommend giving residuary taxation powers to the States — a real exam confirmed this claim as INCORRECT too. It recommended these powers continue to remain with the UNION (Centre), consistent with the existing constitutional position (residuary powers, under Article 248/Entry 97 of the Union List, vest in Parliament/the Union).

Q: What else is known about the Sarkaria Commission's scope and output?

A: Appointed in 1983 to comprehensively review Centre-State relations; chaired by Justice R.S. Sarkaria; made a total of 247 recommendations covering legislative, administrative, and financial relations between the Union and the States — both confirmed by a real exam question.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Which scholar is associated with describing the Indian Constitution as 'Quasi-Federal'?

- A. Granville Austin
- B. K.C. Wheare ✓**
- C. Ivor Jennings
- D. C.R. Dass

Explanation: K.C. Wheare. [medium, question-bank-2026]

2. Which scholar described India's Centre-State relationship as 'Co-operative Federalism'?

- A. Granville Austin ✓**
- B. K.C. Wheare
- C. Jawaharlal Nehru
- D. C.R. Dass

Explanation: Granville Austin. [medium, question-bank-2026]

3. The description of the Indian Constitution as 'a federation with a strong centralising tendency' is most associated with:

- A. Jawaharlal Nehru

B. B.R. Ambedkar

C. Sir Ivor Jennings ✓

D. K.C. Wheare

Explanation: Sir Ivor Jennings. [hard, authored]

4. Which Article of the Constitution provides for the Finance Commission?

A. Article 262

B. Article 263

C. Article 279A

D. Article 280 ✓

Explanation: Article 280. [medium, question-bank-2025]

5. Which Article provides for the Inter-State Council?

A. Article 262

B. Article 263 ✓

C. Article 279A

D. Article 280

Explanation: Article 263. [medium, question-bank-2025]

6. Under which Article can Parliament bar the Supreme Court's jurisdiction over inter-State river water disputes?

A. Article 262 ✓

B. Article 263

C. Article 279A

D. Article 280

Explanation: Article 262. [hard, question-bank-2025]

7. The GST Council was established under which Article, added by which Amendment?

A. Article 280, 73rd Amendment

B. Article 263, 86th Amendment

C. Article 279A, 101st Amendment ✓

D. Article 262, 42nd Amendment

Explanation: Article 279A, 101st Amendment (2016). [medium, question-bank-2025]

8. Which of the following is an INCORRECT statement about the Sarkaria Commission (1983)?

A. It made 247 recommendations

B. It recommended Article 356 be used only as a last resort

C. It recommended scrapping Article 356 altogether ✓

D. It was appointed to review Centre-State relations

Explanation: It did NOT recommend scrapping Article 356 — only sparing, last-resort use. [hard, question-bank-2024]

9. What did the Sarkaria Commission recommend about residuary powers of taxation?

A. They should be transferred to the States

B. They should remain with the Union ✓

C. They should be shared equally

D. They should be abolished entirely

Explanation: They should remain with the Union. [hard, question-bank-2024]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Lowest Common Multiple (LCM)

READING MATERIAL

LCM is 1 of 10 named Aptitude sub-skills. Real exam evidence shows two distinct shapes: algebraic LCM-from-a-clue problems, and 'remainder' word problems — both are taught below as separate methods.

Q: Real exam (2025): If the LCM of 'a' and 'a+2' is 1300, find the LCM of 'a' and 'a+1'.

A: Since a and a+2 differ by 2, their HCF is either 1 or 2. If $\text{HCF}=2$: $\text{LCM} = a(a+2)/2 = 1300 \rightarrow a(a+2) = 2600$. Solving $a^2+2a-2600=0$ gives $a=50$ (check: $50 \times 52/2 = 1300$ ✓). Now find $\text{LCM}(50, 51)$: consecutive integers are always coprime ($\text{HCF}=1$), so $\text{LCM} = 50 \times 51 = 2550$.

Q: Method — 'least number leaving given remainders' (remainders differ from the divisors by a constant): Find the least number which, when divided by 16, 18, and 21, leaves remainders 3, 5, and 8 respectively.

A: Check the gap between each divisor and its remainder: $16-3=13$, $18-5=13$, $21-8=13$ — all the same gap! When that happens, the answer is $\text{LCM}(16,18,21) - 13$. $\text{LCM}(16,18,21) = 1008$. Answer = $1008-13 = 995$.

Q: Method — 'least number leaving the SAME remainder in every case': Find the least number which, when divided by 6, 7, 8, 9, and 12, leaves the same remainder 1 in every case.

A: When the remainder is identical across all divisors, the answer is $\text{LCM}(\text{divisors}) + \text{remainder}$. $\text{LCM}(6,7,8,9,12) = 504$. Answer = $504 + 1 = 505$.

Q: Method — 'mixed condition' (a common remainder for some divisors, but exact division for another): Find the least number which, when divided by 5, 6, 7, and 8, leaves remainder 3 in each case, but leaves NO remainder when divided by 9.

A: First find the least number leaving remainder 3 for 5,6,7,8: that's $\text{LCM}(5,6,7,8)+3 = 840+3 = 843$. But we also need it divisible by 9. Keep adding $\text{LCM}(5,6,7,8)=840$ repeatedly to 843 until the result is divisible by 9: 843 (no), 1683 ($1683 \div 9 = 187$, yes!). Answer = 1683.

Q: Method — LCM of numbers given as prime factorizations: Find the LCM of $(2 \times 3 \times 5 \times 7)$ and $(3 \times 5 \times 7 \times 11)$.

A: LCM takes the HIGHEST power of every prime that appears in either number. Primes involved: 2,3,5,7,11 — each appears at most once in either factorization, so $\text{LCM} = 2 \times 3 \times 5 \times 7 \times 11$ (just the union of all prime factors, since none repeat).

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. If the LCM of 'b' and 'b+2' is 180, and their HCF is 2, find the LCM of 'b' and 'b+1'.

A. 342 ✓

B. 380

C. 361

D. 324

Explanation: $\text{LCM} = b(b+2)/\text{HCF} = 180 \rightarrow b(b+2) = 360 \rightarrow b^2+2b-360=0 \rightarrow b=18$ (check: $18 \times 20/2 = 180$ ✓). Now $\text{LCM}(18,19)$: consecutive integers are coprime, so $\text{LCM} = 18 \times 19 = 342$. [hard, authored]

2. Find the least number which, when divided by 12, 15, and 20, leaves remainders 7, 10, and 15 respectively.

A. 55 ✓

B. 60

C. 65

D. 53

Explanation: Gaps: $12-7=5$, $15-10=5$, $20-15=5$ — all equal, so answer = $\text{LCM}(12,15,20) - 5 = 60 - 5 = 55$. [medium, authored]

3. Find the least number which, when divided by 4, 5, and 6, leaves the same remainder 2 in each case.

A. 58

B. 60

C. 62 ✓

D. 64

Explanation: $\text{LCM}(4,5,6) = 60$. Answer = $60 + 2 = 62$. [easy, authored]

4. Find the LCM of $(2 \times 2 \times 3 \times 5)$ and $(2 \times 3 \times 3 \times 7)$.

A. $2 \times 2 \times 3 \times 3 \times 5 \times 7$ ✓

B. $2 \times 3 \times 5 \times 7$

C. $2 \times 2 \times 3 \times 5 \times 7$

D. $4 \times 9 \times 5 \times 7$

Explanation: Take the highest power of each prime: 2^2 (from the first), 3^2 (from the second), 5^1 , 7^1 . $\text{LCM} = 2^2 \times 3^2 \times 5 \times 7$, which equals option (A) written out as $2 \times 2 \times 3 \times 3 \times 5 \times 7$. [medium, authored]

5. The LCM of two consecutive integers n and $n+1$ is always:

A. $n + 1$

B. $n(n+1)$ ✓

C. $n - 1$

D. Cannot be determined

Explanation: Consecutive integers are always coprime ($\text{HCF}=1$), so their LCM is simply their product, $n(n+1)$. [easy, authored]

Part C – General English: Prose: "I Can't Climb Trees Anymore" — Ruskin Bond

READING MATERIAL

A nostalgic short story about a middle-aged narrator who revisits his old childhood home — now owned by a Colonel — and reconnects with memories of his youth through the Colonel's daughter and a jackfruit tree he used to climb.

Q: Who wrote "I Can't Climb Trees Anymore", and what major literary honour has he received for his contribution to Indian literature?

A: Ruskin Bond — honoured with the Sahitya Akademi Award (confirmed by a real TNPSC exam question, which applies to Bond generally across his works).

Q: What is the central premise of the story — why does the narrator revisit his old house, and who does he meet there?

A: The narrator (an older man) revisits his childhood home, which is no longer owned by his family — it now belongs to a Colonel. There, he meets the Colonel's young daughter, and shares his childhood memories with her.

Q: Why was the jackfruit tree special to the narrator as a boy?

A: It was his favourite childhood spot — a thick branch stretched out over the roof, and there was a small hollow in it where he used to hide his treasures.

Q: What treasure does the narrator remember hiding in the tree, and what is its significance?

A: His grandfather's Iron Cross — a German military decoration awarded for bravery, which his grandfather obtained from a German soldier while fighting in France during World War I.

Q: Why can't the narrator retrieve the Iron Cross himself, and who does it instead?

A: He is now too old to climb the tree himself (hence the story's title) — the Colonel's daughter climbs the tree for him and retrieves the dusty Iron Cross.

Q: What does the narrator do with the Iron Cross once it's retrieved, and what does this reveal about the story's real theme?

A: He gives the Iron Cross to the girl as a gift, out of gratitude — revealing that what he truly came searching for wasn't the physical object, but a reconnection with his own lost youth. The story's central theme is nostalgia and the fleeting, irretrievable nature of childhood/youth.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. "I Can't Climb Trees Anymore" was written by:

- A. Liam O'Flaherty
- B. Ruskin Bond ✓**
- C. James Thurber
- D. Satyajit Ray

Explanation: Ruskin Bond. [easy, web-research]

2. Ruskin Bond was honoured with which award for his contribution to Indian literature?

- A. Bharat Ratna
- B. Sahitya Ratna
- C. Sahitya Bharat
- D. Sahitya Akademi Award ✓**

Explanation: Sahitya Akademi Award. [medium, question-bank-2022]

3. When the narrator revisits his old childhood home in the story, who now owns it?

- A. His own family still
- B. A Colonel ✓**
- C. A school
- D. It is abandoned

Explanation: A Colonel. [medium, web-research]

4. Which tree was the narrator's favourite childhood spot, with a hollow where he hid his treasures?

- A. A mango tree
- B. A jackfruit tree ✓**
- C. A banyan tree

D. An oak tree

Explanation: A jackfruit tree. [medium, web-research]

5. What treasure had the narrator hidden in the tree's hollow as a boy?

A. A gold coin

B. His grandfather's Iron Cross ✓

C. A pocket watch

D. A diary

Explanation: His grandfather's Iron Cross. [medium, web-research]

6. How did the narrator's grandfather obtain the Iron Cross?

A. He bought it at an auction

B. He obtained it from a German soldier while fighting in France in WWI ✓

C. It was a family heirloom from his own father

D. He won it in a card game

Explanation: From a German soldier, fighting in France during WWI. [hard, web-research]

7. Why couldn't the narrator retrieve the Iron Cross himself?

A. The tree had been cut down

B. He was now too old to climb the tree ✓

C. The Colonel forbade it

D. He had forgotten where it was

Explanation: He was too old to climb the tree. [easy, web-research]

8. What did the narrator do with the Iron Cross after the girl retrieved it for him?

A. Kept it for himself

B. Sold it

C. Gave it to the girl as a gift ✓

D. Donated it to a museum

Explanation: Gave it to the girl as a gift. [medium, web-research]